Does this mean that the economy does not matter politically in contemporary India? The idea that politics follows economics has been conventional wisdom, at least since the American political strategist James Carville put up a notice saying 'The economy, stupid' outside Bill Clinton's campaign office in 1992. Was this wisdom checkmated in India by Modi's cocktail of personality politics and a virulent Hindutva-infused, post-Balakot muscular nationalism? Conversely, were the country's economic concerns overhyped by naysayers, as the government argued? Or were people being hoodwinked by clever propaganda and identity politics, as the Congress argued? In other words, were Indian voters voting against their own economic self-interest, much like white male Republican voters in the US backing President Donald Trump?[24]

The Opposition's beliefs were best exemplified by the Congress's caustic '*Bhakt ka chashma*' campaign video in 2019 (see details in Chapter 7).[25] The broad assumption among the elite is that people are gullible, are not as aware of their own realities as they should be, and are being carried away by a 'propaganda machinery', as Congress scion Priyanka Gandhi put it.

Figure 10.2: Unemployment Rates in India, by State